The Shifting Lens of Ostracism: Exploring the Impact of Social Exclusion on Situational Perception Dimensions.

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EFFECT OF SOCIAL EXCLUSION ON DIMENSIONS OF SITUATIONAL PERCEPTION

Abstract

Does a change in situational cues directly influence our perception of them? This study offers novel experimental evidence that situational changes directly affect our perception, focusing on how ostracism influences situational perception and its impact compared to personality traits on feelings of exclusion. Through both between-subject (Study 1, n=349) and within-subject designs (Study 2, n=259), we demonstrate that ostracism significantly alters perceptions, increasing negativity and adversity while reducing positivity. Notably, situational perception proved to be a stronger predictor of feelings of neglect and exclusion than Big Five personality traits in both studies, with positivity and negativity as key factors in the impact of ostracism. This research advances our understanding of social exclusion's psychological mechanisms and highlights the importance of measuring situational perception in exploring the person-situation interaction debate.

Keywords: social exclusion; Big Five; DIAMONDS; situational perception; experiment

EFFECT OF SOCIAL EXCLUSION ON DIMENSIONS OF SITUATIONAL PERCEPTION

Do situations define a person's behavior or do people experience and shape their own situations? The current literature has focused on these points as part of an ongoing debate regarding the various links between people, situations, and their behavior (Rauthmann et al., 2016). The joint influence of personal characteristics and situational factors on behavior has been a central principle in social psychology since the pioneering work of Lewin (1936). Moreover, contemporary theories emphasize that individuals' subjective construal of situations often exerts a stronger influence on psychological outcomes than the objective features of the environment itself (Wilson, 2022). In this tradition, a growing body of research has examined how situational perceptions shape experiences and behavior. Building upon this foundation, the present research applies the structured dimensional framework of situational perception proposed by Rauthmann et al. (2014) — the DIAMONDS taxonomy — to the study of ostracism, an area where such dimensional approaches remain relatively underexplored. Our objective is to experimentally examine if changes in the objective properties of situations lead to changes in situational perception. In other words, we aim to experimentally test the extent to which situations influence the perception of situations.

Rauthmann and colleagues (2016) highlight the person-situation debate as a cornerstone in the field, which suggests that (a) behavior may not be as consistent as is often believed, and (b) that situations determine behavior (for a comprehensive review, see: Fleeson & Noftle, 2008). The crux of the issue lies within the uncertainty of the question posed by Rauthmann et al. (2016) regarding whether situations can predict behavior, or if behavior can predict situations. Currently, there is still a lack of experimental evidence on how situational changes can alter situational perceptions. Focusing on the impact of social exclusion, we employ two distinct approaches: one analyzing between-subject differences and the other exploring within-subject differences, aiming to enhance the current

understanding of the dynamic interaction between situation and personality in shaping behavior.

Background

Recent studies have predominantly addressed the influence of personality traits on behavioral outcomes and situational perception, recognizing traits as adaptive mechanisms for both individual and collective survival, and as potential influences on the shaping of situations (Blum & Schmitt, 2015; Donnellan & Corker, 2015; Funder, 2016; Rauthmann & Sherman, 2018; Rauthmann et al., 2014). While traits are consistent over time, situations are dynamic and fluctuate more frequently, impacting personality states rather than traits (Asendorpf, 2015; Horstmann & Ziegler, 2020; Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015).

Research has extensively explored personality and situational perception by observing participants' reactions in various situations (Morse et al., 2015). Blum & Schmitt (2015) suggest that analyzing personality traits and behaviors across different contexts can enhance our understanding since both personality and situational responses are considered trait-based yet occasion-dependent. They describe personality states as behavior expectations tied to individuals and specific occasions, while situational states relate to expected behaviors in given situations and occasions. Studying the interplay between personality and situational contexts, as observed in scenarios like the Cyberball experiment in social psychology, can enhance our understanding of situational effects on behavior (Gallardo-Pujol & Buades-Rotger, 2015; Gallardo-Pujol & Buades-Rotger, 2019).

The Dawn of Situational Research

Although the role of situations in behavior has been emphasized since Lewin's early formulations, research on situations has historically lagged other areas of psychology. As Hogan (2009) pointed out, the conceptualization of situations has often been fragmented and

lacking a common language or standardized framework, making systematic study difficult. Researchers typically relied on ad hoc methods to create and assess specific situations—such as using the Cyberball game to induce social exclusion—and then measured participants' responses or subjective ratings. This lack of standardization contrasts with the development of robust taxonomies in other areas, such as the Big Five model for personality traits. Recent advances, however, advocate for more systematic integration of situation assessment methods to better capture the psychological properties of situations (Funder, 2016; Rauthmann et al., 2014; Rauthmann & Sherman, 2018; Williams et al., 2012; Gallardo-Pujol et al., 2013). We selected the Cyberball task precisely because it allows for the manipulation of a single, objective cue—the number of ball tosses received—while keeping all other situational aspects constant. This provides a highly controlled context to examine the effects of situational changes on perception.

Social exclusion reliably triggers strong and immediate negative emotional responses across diverse contexts and groups, suggesting a robust and universal effect (Gonsalkorale & Williams, 2007; Van Beest & Williams, 2006). According to the Temporal Need-Threat Model (Williams, 2009), the immediate experience of ostracism is largely impervious to moderation by personality traits, as it threatens fundamental social needs in a rapid, reflexive manner. Empirical research has supported this idea, showing that dispositional factors exert minimal influence on early emotional responses to exclusion (McDonald & Donnellan, 2012; Yaakobi, 2022). Zadro et al. (2004) further demonstrated that even when participants were aware that the exclusion was artificial or part of an experimental manipulation, they still reported strong negative reactions, highlighting the automatic and powerful nature of situational cues. Nevertheless, while early emotional reactions may show little variability, less is known about how individuals cognitively appraise situational features following exclusion. Prior work has tended to focus on emotional outcomes rather than perceptions of

the situation itself. Building on this distinction, the present study explores whether situational perceptions following inclusion and exclusion are shaped primarily by the immediate social context or by stable personality traits, thus extending the literature by shifting the focus from emotional consequences to cognitive appraisals.

Several structured approaches have been developed to conceptualize and measure situational perceptions. The Situational Construal Model (Funder, 2016) emphasizes that individuals' subjective interpretations, rather than objective features, define the psychological meaning of situations (Wilson, 2022). This represents an important evolution from earlier experimental traditions that focused mainly on manipulating objective cues (e.g., Milgram, 1974; Richard et al., 2003), highlighting that situational characteristics are jointly shaped by both external affordances and subjective construals.

Building on this principle, several structured approaches have been developed to capture situational perception systematically. The Riverside Situational Q-Sort (RSQ) (Funder et al., 2000) identifies 90 psychologically meaningful situational attributes, organized into broader domains such as intellectual engagement or interpersonal conflict. From this, more parsimonious taxonomies emerged. The Situational Eight DIAMONDS taxonomy (Rauthmann et al., 2014, 2018) — derived through factor analytic methods — summarizes situational characteristics into eight fundamental dimensions: Duty, Intellect, Adversity, Mating, Positivity, Negativity, Deception, and Sociality. These dimensions capture key situational qualities: Duty reflects obligations and tasks; Intellect relates to cognitive stimulation and opportunities for thinking; Adversity involves threat, conflict, or difficulty; Mating concerns opportunities for romance or sexuality; Positivity captures pleasantness and enjoyment; Negativity reflects unpleasantness and frustration; Deception involves mistrust or manipulation; and Sociality reflects opportunities for social interaction and connection. This dimensional framework has been shown to capture how situations are

psychologically construed beyond personality traits alone (Ziegler, Horstmann, & Ziegler, 2019). In parallel, the CAPTION model (Parrigon et al., 2017) offers a lexically-derived structure that organizes situations along seven key dimensions, such as Complexity, Adversity, Positivity, Typicality, Importance, Negativity, and Sociality. In the present research, we focus on the DIAMONDS taxonomy to systematically examine how ostracism shapes individuals' situational perceptions across these core psychological dimensions.

In fact, systematic measurement of situational characteristics has not been a focus, despite their importance in shaping individual perceptions of dynamic and transient circumstances. This gap highlights the need for measurement approaches that capture the nuanced effects of situations as perceived and interpreted by individuals (Rauthmann & Sherman, 2018). Rauthmann & Sherman (2018) put forward the example of ostracism, inducing two different conditions, social exclusion vs. inclusion, using the Cyberball game by Williams et al. (2012). Cyberball is a ball-tossing game with alleged co-players wherein participants either receive the ball regularly (inclusion) or stop receiving it after a few tosses (exclusion). This example focuses on how a single stimulus (or cue: ball-tossings) can be manipulated, and its effects on affect and behavior are examined post hoc. The interpretation of these differences could be improved with the addition of situational assessment tools. Tools that assess situation perceptions can reveal differences in individual experiences, indicating if an experimental manipulation was effective and whether these perceptions play a mediating role in the relationship between stimuli and responses. In research, collecting situational ratings from participants directly involved, observers, and outsiders can provide a triangulated, comprehensive view of the situation (Rauthmann & Sherman, 2018).

Donnellan and Corker (2015) advocate for the continued use of experimental manipulations like the Cyberball game to delve into the consistent effects of various situations, such as social exclusion. This approach has significantly contributed to

understanding ostracism, revealing substantial psychological impacts (Hartgerink et al., 2015). It is important to note that our study focuses exclusively on perceptions of situations and affective responses rather than directly measuring behavioral outcomes. Reliable methods like these facilitate a deeper comprehension of causal relationships and how situations may elicit certain trait behaviors (Egloff et al., 2015; Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015).

Hence, previous research suggests that early emotional reactions to social exclusion are relatively automatic and not strongly moderated by individual differences in personality traits. Besides McDonald and Donnellan (2012) who found that dispositional traits exert minimal influence on immediate emotional responses to ostracism, Hales et al. (2016) observed that disagreeableness was more likely to emerge as a consequence of ostracism experiences rather than as a strong predictor of initial emotional responses. These findings align with the Temporal Need-Threat Model (Williams, 2009), which posits that ostracism reflexively threatens fundamental human needs in a relatively universal manner. In line with this theoretical and empirical background, we hypothesize that situational perceptions — rather than stable personality traits — would predominantly predict emotional responses to social exclusion in the present studies.

The Present Research

Building on this evidence, the present research aims to examine how situational cues and personality traits contribute to the perception of inclusion and exclusion contexts through two studies. The first study evaluates participants' perceptions post-Cyberball game using a between-participants' design (Williams et al., 2012, Gallardo-Pujol et al., 2013). Previous research has shown that situational perceptions are closely related to individuals' emotional experiences. For example, Jones et al. (2017) demonstrated that situational characteristics

such as adversity and positivity strongly predict happiness, with perceptions of adversity being negatively and perceptions of positivity being positively associated with subjective well-being. Similarly, Horstmann et al. (2020) and Horstmann and Ziegler (2019) found that momentary situational perceptions — particularly along the Positivity and Negativity dimensions of the DIAMONDS — were robust predictors of affective states across different samples and settings. Brown et al. (2015) also showed that everyday situational construals involving positive versus negative appraisals influence emotional outcomes. Building on these findings, we formulated hypotheses for Study 1, predicting that ostracism would alter situational perceptions along specific DIAMONDS dimensions (e.g., increased perceptions of adversity and negativity, decreased perceptions of positivity), and that these altered perceptions would relate to emotional responses following social exclusion.

The results of Study 1 were used to derive the hypotheses of Study 2 (within-participants) concerning predictions and effect sizes. Both studies utilized identical measures. The OSF repository (https://osf.io/yw64e/?view_only=bc5ed88572fd4cd29ea1860cca71c468) contains all raw data files, code used for analyses, and supplementary materials necessary to fully reproduce the results reported in both empirical studies. This study was not preregistered.

Figure 1 provides a summarized visual representation of the research question, objectives, methods, and hypotheses for both studies.

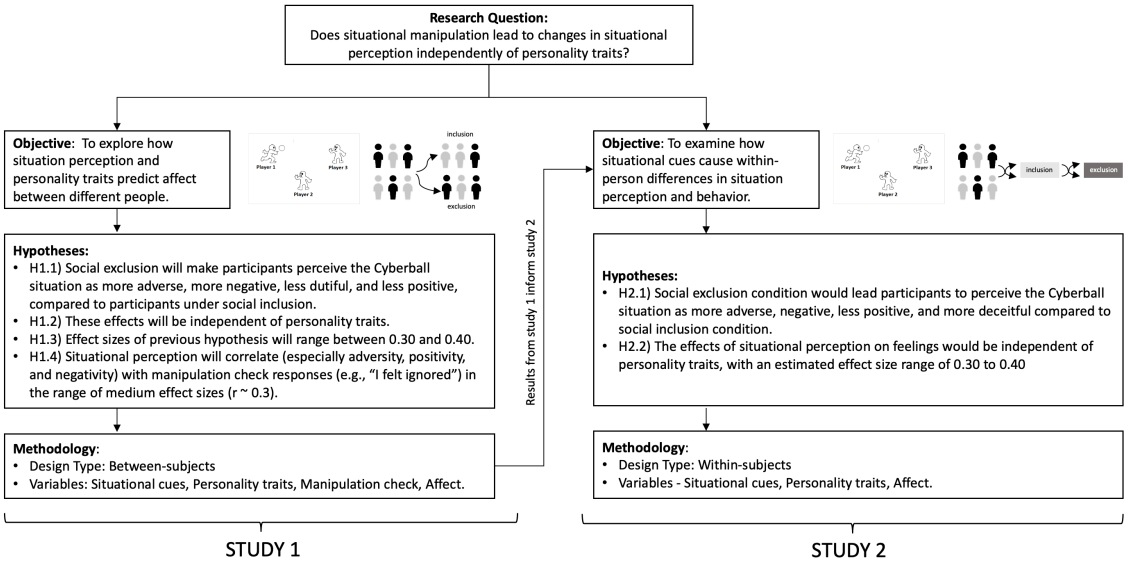


Figure 1

Flowchart overview of the studies in this article.

Study 1

Research Questions

Our research focused on two main questions: 1) whether social exclusion alters one's perception of a situation as more negative, and 2) whether personality traits along with situational perception influence feelings of neglect and exclusion. To address our research questions, we formulated hypotheses based on Horstmann & Ziegler (2019) and Brown et al. (2015) regarding situational perception's impact on affect. We propose: H1.1) Social exclusion alters situational perception to be more adverse and negative, and less dutiful and positive. H1.2) These effects are not influenced by personality traits. H1.3) Expected effect sizes for H1.2 are between 0.30 and 0.40, derived from Horstmann & Ziegler (2019; ß ~.38) and Sherman et al. (2015; ß ~ .35). These hypotheses will be tested at an alpha of .05, following Läkens (2022).

Overview

Study 1 seeks to build upon Rauthmann & Sherman's (2016) research on how situational changes affect perception, moving beyond their correlational methodology to include experimental manipulation for a more accurate assessment of causality, even when a causal timeline exists (Pearl, 2009) through longitudinal designs or ecological momentary assessment (EMA; Horstmann et al., 2019).

Method

Power analysis. Guided by Läkens (2022), we utilized Monte-Carlo simulations to identify the sample size required for 80% power at an alpha of .05, referencing McDonald & Donnellan (2012) and Sherman et al. (2015) for effect sizes in personality and situational variables, respectively. Initial simulations suggested 350 participants provided at least 80% power for personality variables. We adjusted our sample size to over 450 to ensure at least 90% power, as recommended by Schöndbrot & Perugini (2013) and detailed in our supplementary materials (https://osf.io/yw64e/?view_only=bc5ed88572fd4cd29ea1860cca71c468).

Sample. Data for Study 1 were collected between March and September 2019 in Northeastern Spain. A total of 484 young adults primarily female (80.8%), completed the survey through convenience sampling, with ages 18 to 67 (M = 21.82, SD = 7.21). Of these, 28 (5.7%) were not students and joined online. Of these, 349 participants with complete data on the key variables were retained for the analyses. Participants with missing responses on any critical study measures were excluded to ensure data quality. Although the exclusion criteria were not preregistered, the decision was based on standard practices to maintain consistency across analyses. No other exclusion criteria were applied.

Procedure. *Ostracism Induction.* The Cyberball game (Williams & Jarvis, 2006) was employed to simulate a ball-tossing session among three avatars, aimed at evoking feelings of

inclusion or exclusion among participants, who controlled an avatar for approximately 6 minutes. This approach has been previously validated for its effectiveness in eliciting such feelings (Hartgerink et al., 2015; Gallardo-Pujol et al., 2013; Zadro et al., 2006).

Design. We employed a between-subjects design for Study 1, splitting participants into two groups and randomly assigning to them: those excluded (N = 187) from receiving the ball and those included (N = 162).

Ethics statement. This study, approved by an Institutional Review Board (00003099), followed ethical guidelines for human research. Participants were informed about the study's goals, data anonymization for publication, and their right to withdraw at any time without consequence. Informed consent was obtained prior to participation.

Measures.

Mood States. To assess the effects of ostracism, participants completed a set of items drawn from the Post Experimental Questionnaire of Primary Needs (PEQPN; Zadro et al., 2014), focusing on mood and feelings of neglect and exclusion. Participants rated their agreement on a Likert scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Specifically, the statements "I felt ignored" and "I felt excluded" were used as key dependent variables. Given that these mood and need threat states were assessed using single-item measures, reliability coefficients were not computed. Although the 'ignored' and 'excluded' items are highly correlated in the literature, we treated them as separate dependent variables to capture potential subtle distinctions between passive disregard (ignored) and active rejection (excluded), in line with theoretical models of ostracism (e.g., Williams, 2009; Wesselmann et al., 2015).

Personality. The Big Five personality traits—Extraversion, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness, Negative Emotionality, and Open-Mindedness—were assessed using the

Big Five Inventory-2 (BFI-2; Gallardo-Pujol et al., 2022; Soto & John, 2017a). Participants rated 60 items on a Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Scores for each trait dimension were calculated by averaging the corresponding items. Reliability coefficients (McDonald's ω) ranged from .79 (Agreeableness) to .88 (Negative Emotionality). The Spanish adaptation of the BFI-2 was used (Gallardo-Pujol et al., 2022).

Situational Perception. Participants' situational perceptions were assessed using the Situational Eight DIAMONDS Ultra Brief (Rauthmann & Sherman, 2016), which consists of one item per situational dimension (Duty, Intellect, Adversity, Mating, Positivity, Negativity, Deception, and Sociality) rated on a 1 to 5 Likert scale. Because each dimension was measured with a single item, reliability coefficients were not computed.

Analytical plan.

This study investigated the connections between the Big Five personality traits, the DIAMONDS dimensions, and mood states through Pearson's correlation coefficients, with Welch t-tests assessing experimental condition impacts. Effect sizes were measured using Cohen's *d*. Multiple regression models explored predictions of social exclusion markers and mood states by the Big Five and situational perceptions, controlling for multicollinearity without detecting significant outliers. This analysis facilitated a comparison of the relative contributions of personality traits and situational perceptions to the observed outcomes.

Results

Descriptives and associations between variables. Descriptive statistics for the DIAMONDS, Big Five, and Mood States are presented in Table 1, showing specific ratings for the Cyberball exclusion situation across various dimensions. Notably, the situation scored high on Duty, Negativity, and Sociality, but low on Positivity, with no significant ratings in

Mating, Intellect, or Adversity (correlations between all variables are in Figure SM1, supplementary materials). Table 2 further details the DIAMONDS' means by experimental condition. Big Five means were found to be within the normal range (Gallardo-Pujol et al., 2022). Pearson's correlations revealed that feelings of exclusion or ignorance correlated positively with Negative Emotionality and negatively with Extraversion and Open-mindedness. Specific DIAMONDS dimensions such as Adversity, Negativity, and Deception showed positive associations with feelings of exclusion, whereas Positivity had a negative association. Personality traits showed modest correlations with situational perceptions, with Adversity and Negativity relating to specific traits like Extraversion and Agreeableness, respectively. Feelings of neglect and feelings of exclusion showed a correlation of .93.

Table 1

Means and standard deviations

Variable	*M*	*SD*
1. E	3.49	0.60
2. A	3.84	0.52
3. N	3.26	0.68
4. C	3.32	0.61
5. O	3.84	0.55
6. Duty	9.56	2.91
7. Intellect	5.54	3.00
8. Adversity	6.50	3.26
9. Mating	5.32	2.77
10. Positivity	8.90	3.33
11. Negativity	9.11	3.60
12. Deception	8.04	3.11
13. Sociality	9.05	3.27
14. Angry	2.50	1.29
15. Good	3.03	1.06
16. Bad	2.20	1.13
17. Happy	2.72	1.08
18. Sad	2.34	1.20
19. Friendly	2.90	1.12
20. Unfriendly	2.16	1.15
21. Tense	2.80	1.30
22. Relaxed	2.83	1.19
23. Ignored	3.69	1.39
24. Excluded	3.58	1.45

Note: N=349; E=Extraversion; A=Agreeableness; N=Negative Emotionality; C=Conscientiousness; O=Open-mindedness.

Differences in situational perception. Following the Cyberball game, Welch two-sample *t*-tests revealed that social exclusion significantly alters situational perceptions. Social exclusion was associated with increased Adversity and decreased Positivity, alongside heightened perceptions of Negativity and Deception, as indicated by significant *t*-test results and Cohen's *d* values, with the largest discrepancy observed in Negativity (Table 2; Figure 2). This underscores that social exclusion profoundly impacts situational perception as outlined by the DIAMONDS model.

Table 2.

Mean differences in situational perception between excluded and included participants.

	Excluded mean	**Included mean**	***t***	**95% Lower CI**	**85% Upper CI**	**p-value**	**Cohen's *d***	**95% Lower CI**	**95% Upper Ci**
Duty	9.74	9.34	1.30	-0.21	1.02	.19	0.14	-0.07	0.35
Intellect	5.47	5.63	-0.51	-0.80	0.47	.61	-0.05	-0.27	0.16
Adversity	7.32	5.56	5.26	1.10	2.41	<.001	0.56	0.34	0.77
Mating	5.39	5.23	0.51	-0.43	0.74	.61	0.05	-0.16	0.27
Positivity	7.88	10.07	-6.44	-2.86	-1.52	<.001	-0.70	-0.91	-0.48
Negativity	10.71	7.27	10.07	2.76	4.11	<.001	1.08	0.86	1.31
Deception	8.65	7.35	3.97	0.66	1.95	<.001	0.43	0.21	0.64
Sociality	9.05	9.05	0.00	-0.70	0.70	1.00	0.00	-0.21	0.21

Note: N=349

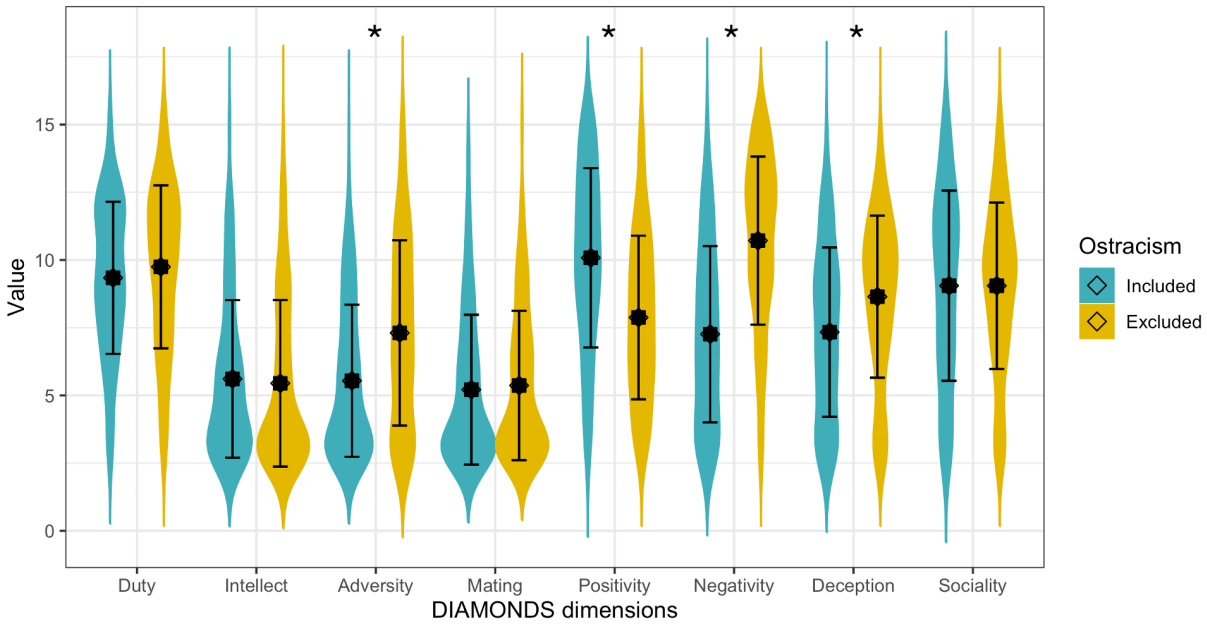


Figure 2. Violin plots of situational perception as a function of experimental condition. Note: Black squares represent the means and lines represent standard deviations. Asterisks indicate significant differences. N=349.

Prediction of feelings of neglect and exclusion. We explored how well the Big Five personality traits and the DIAMONDS dimensions could predict feelings of neglect and exclusion. Through two linear regression models[1] (Tables 3 and 4), we found that combining these predictors accounted for up to 48% of the variance in feelings of being ignored, after adjusting for mutual influences. Specifically, Adversity, Positivity, and Negativity from the DIAMONDS significantly influenced the perception of being ignored, with no Big Five dimensions significantly contributing to this variance, despite notable semi-partial correlations with Extraversion (E), Negative Emotionality (N), and Open-mindedness (O).

[1]To ensure the robustness of our findings and further validate them, we conducted control analyses including the experimental condition (ostracized vs. included) as an additional predictor. Results remained consistent, with situational perceptions and key personality traits continuing to explain variance beyond the experimental manipulation (see Supplementary Material). Importantly, the associations between situational perceptions and feelings of neglect and exclusion remain correlational.

Table 3

Regression results using "I felt ignored" as the criterion

Predictor	*b*	*b* 95% CI [LL, UL]	*beta*	*beta* 95% CI [LL, UL]	sr^2	sr^2 95% CI [LL, UL]	*r*	Fit
(Intercept)	3.13**	[1.60, 4.65]						
E	-0.13	[-0.34, 0.08]	-0.06	[-0.15, 0.03]	.00	[-.00, .01]	-.12*	
A	0.05	[-0.18, 0.28]	0.02	[-0.07, 0.11]	.00	[-.00, .00]	-.09	
C	0.14	[-0.06, 0.34]	0.06	[-0.03, 0.15]	.00	[-.01, .01]	.01	
N	0.06	[-0.12, 0.24]	0.03	[-0.06, 0.12]	.00	[-.00, .00]	.15**	
O	-0.16	[-0.37, 0.05]	-0.06	[-0.15, 0.02]	.00	[-.01, .01]	-.12*	
Duty	-0.03	[-0.07, 0.01]	-0.07	[-0.15, 0.02]	.00	[-.01, .01]	-.01	
Intellect	-0.04	[-0.08, 0.01]	-0.08	[-0.17, 0.02]	.00	[-.01, .01]	-.08	
Adversity	0.06**	[0.02, 0.11]	0.15	[0.04, 0.26]	.01	[-.00, .03]	.41**	
Mating	-0.04	[-0.09, 0.00]	-0.09	[-0.19, 0.01]	.00	[-.01, .02]	.03	
Positivity	-0.08**	[-0.12, -0.04]	-0.20	[-0.30, -0.10]	.03	[.00, .05]	-.40**	
Negativity	0.19**	[0.15, 0.23]	0.50	[0.39, 0.60]	.13	[.08, .18]	.63**	
Deception	0.02	[-0.03, 0.06]	0.03	[-0.06, 0.13]	.00	[-.00, .00]	.31**	
Sociality	-0.00	[-0.04, 0.04]	-0.00	[-0.10, 0.09]	.00	[-.00, .00]	.01	
								R^2 = .484** 95% CI[.39,.53]

Note. A significant *b*-weight indicates the beta-weight and semi-partial correlation are also significant. *b* represents unstandardized regression weights. *beta* indicates the standardized regression weights. sr^2 represents the semi-partial correlation squared. *r* represents the zero-order correlation. *LL* and *UL* indicate the lower and upper limits of a confidence interval, respectively. E represents extraversion, A represents agreeableness, C represents conscientiousness, N represents negative emotionality, and O represents open mindedness. N=349; * indicates $p < .05$. ** indicates $p < .01$.

Table 4 outlines regression results for feelings of exclusion, showing a similar trend to feelings of being ignored. The Big Five traits did not significantly contribute to explaining variance beyond what was accounted for by the DIAMONDS dimensions. Adversity, Positivity, and Negativity from the DIAMONDS were significant predictors, explaining up to 53% of the variance in feelings of social exclusion after mutual adjustments. Negativity emerged as the strongest predictor in both scenarios of feeling ignored and excluded.

Table 4

Regression results using "I felt excluded" as the criterion

Predictor	*b*	*b* 95% CI [LL, UL]	*ß*	*beta* 95% CI [LL, UL]	sr^2	sr^2 95% CI [LL, UL]	*r*	Fit
(Intercept)	2.84**	[1.31, 4.37]						
E	-0.16	[-0.37, 0.05]	-0.07	[-0.15, 0.02]	.00	[-.00, .01]	-.13*	
A	0.12	[-0.11, 0.36]	0.04	[-0.04, 0.13]	.00	[-.00, .01]	-.08	
C	0.03	[-0.17, 0.23]	0.01	[-0.07, 0.10]	.00	[-.00, .00]	-.02	
N	0.02	[-0.16, 0.20]	0.01	[-0.07, 0.09]	.00	[-.00, .00]	.13*	
O	-0.16	[-0.38, 0.05]	-0.06	[-0.14, 0.02]	.00	[-.01, .01]	-.11*	
Duty	-0.01	[-0.05, 0.03]	-0.03	[-0.11, 0.05]	.00	[-.00, .00]	.03	
Intellect	-0.04	[-0.09, 0.00]	-0.09	[-0.18, 0.00]	.01	[-.01, .02]	-.07	
Adversity	0.05*	[0.01, 0.10]	0.12	[0.01, 0.22]	.01	[-.01, .02]	.42**	
Mating	-0.05	[-0.09, 0.00]	-0.09	[-0.18, 0.01]	.00	[-.01, .01]	.05	
Positivity	-0.08**	[-0.12, -0.04]	-0.18	[-0.27, -0.09]	.02	[-.00, .04]	-.39**	
Negativity	0.22**	[0.18, 0.26]	0.55	[0.44, 0.65]	.16	[.10, .21]	.67**	
Deception	0.03	[-0.01, 0.08]	0.07	[-0.02, 0.16]	.00	[-.00, .01]	.36**	
Sociality	-0.00	[-0.04, 0.04]	-0.01	[-0.10, 0.09]	.00	[-.00, .00]	.04	
								R^2 = .525** 95% CI[.44,.57]

Note. A significant *b*-weight indicates the beta-weight and semi-partial correlation are also significant. *b* represents unstandardized regression weights. *beta* indicates the standardized regression weights. sr^2 represents the semi-partial correlation squared. *r* represents the zero-order correlation. *LL* and *UL* indicate the lower and upper limits of a confidence interval, respectively. E represents extraversion, A represents agreeableness, C represents conscientiousness, N represents negative emotionality, and O represents open mindedness. Note: N=349. * indicates $p < .05$. ** indicates $p < .01$.

Unique prediction and variance partitioning. Figure 3 illustrates the cumulative effects of the DIAMONDS dimensions and the Big Five on the variance explained for feelings of social exclusion and mood states, with details in Supplementary Tables SM1 and SM2. It highlights that situational perception consistently accounted for a larger portion of the explained variance compared to personality traits, which contributed minimally. Specifically, for feelings of exclusion, situational perception's unique effects were around 20%, while for mood states, these effects varied between 6.47% and 14.60%. In contrast, the Big Five's unique impact ranged from a negligible 0.17% to 1.60%, underscoring the greater explanatory power of situational factors over personality traits in these contexts[2].

[2] The results of the regressions for all the mood states are displayed in tables SM4 to SM12.

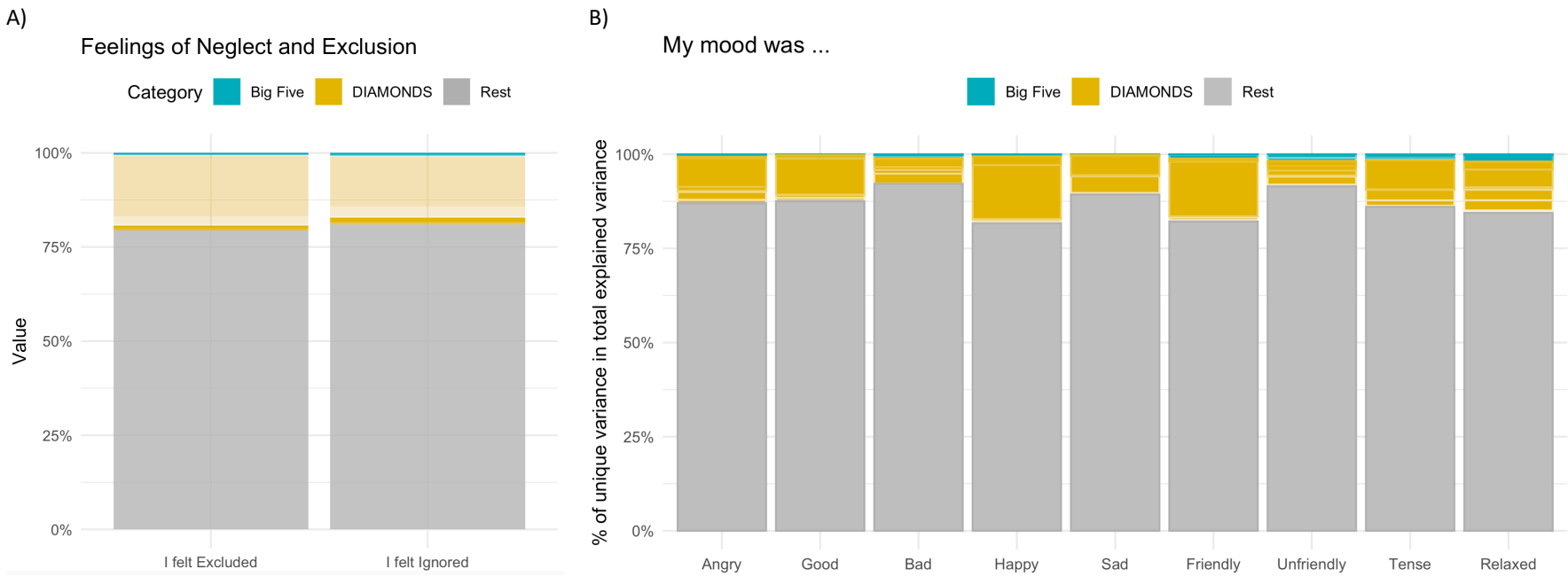


Figure 3

Unique effects of situational perception (DIAMONDS) and personality (Big Five) on variance of feelings of neglect and exclusion (panel A) and mood states (panel B). Slight color variations within each bar correspond to different predictors within the same category. See Supplementary Tables SM1 to SM3 for the exact unique effect values. N=349.

Discussion

This study sought to expand upon Rauthmann and Sherman's (2016) research into how situations and perceptions thereof evolve, through experimental manipulation and randomization. The goal was to better explore the potential causal links in social interaction dynamics and to provide insights into how experimental manipulations may influence the psychological characteristics of situations.

The results demonstrate that the experimental setup effectively altered participants' perceptions within the Cyberball game, leading to feelings of exclusion and neglect. Those subjected to exclusion perceived more adversity, negativity, and deception, and less positivity, supporting H1.1. This shows that social exclusion cues markedly affect situational perceptions, aligning with the DIAMONDS model's predictions.

Our analysis within a componential variance framework (Rauthmann & Sherman, 2018) revealed that situational perceptions, especially Adversity, Positivity, and Negativity, significantly influenced feelings of neglect and exclusion, unlike the Big Five personality traits which added no further explanatory power. Given the strong correlation between feelings of being ignored and excluded, findings should be interpreted with caution regarding their conceptual overlap. Situational perception was found to contribute more to the variance in both markers of social exclusion (H1.2), with its unique effects on these feelings and mood states ranging between .15 (Adversity) and .50 (Negativity), supporting and sometimes exceeding our expectations (H1.3). This underscores the critical role of situational perception in explaining social dynamics.

Study 2

Research questions

Study 2 aimed to explore changes in situational perception within individuals affected by social inclusion or exclusion, replicating and extending findings from our initial study on the connection between situational perception and affect. We posited that H2.1) being in a social exclusion condition would cause participants to view the Cyberball situation as more adverse, negative, less positive, and deceitful compared to social inclusion condition. Further, we conjectured that H2.2) the impact of situational perception on emotional responses would be independent from personality traits. We anticipated a moderate correlation between situational perception and both mood states and feelings of neglect and exclusion, expecting effect sizes between 0.30 and 0.40, and used a .05 alpha level for testing, following Läkens's (2022) guidelines.

Overview

Study 2 pursued goals akin to Study 1 but employed a within-subjects design to further explore Rauthmann and Sherman's (2016) investigations into how situations change and are perceived, providing a stronger basis for examining hypothesized effects and improving the robustness of the findings. The within-subjects methodology notably enhanced the study's ability to control for confounders and increased analytical power, thereby deepening our understanding of situational dynamics and perceptions with heightened methodological rigor.

Method

Power analysis and determination of sample size. A Monte-Carlo simulation power analysis (Läkens, 2022), was conducted to estimate the sample size required to achieve at least 80% power with an alpha of .05 for the expected effect sizes. Drawing on prior effect sizes from Sherman et al. (2015) and Study 1, with means of .35 and .34 respectively, it was determined that 134 observations would provide 80% power to detect an effect size of d=.35 in a within-subjects design. Consequently, we aimed for a sample size greater than 300 to

attain around 90% power, enabling the detection of smaller effects (e.g., d = .27) with sufficient power. Further details are available in the supplementary material (https://osf.io/yw64e/?view_only=bc5ed88572fd4cd29ea1860cca71c468).

Sample and procedure.

Data for Study 2 were collected between May and June 2020, under the same recruitment and data collection conditions as Study 1, in Northeastern Spain. Data collection took place shortly after the first COVID-19 lockdown. The study began with 302 first-year undergraduate participants, who received course credits for full participation. A total of 43 participants (14.23%) did not complete the study, resulting in a final sample of 259, with 214 (82.62%) being female, and ages ranging from 18 to 41 (M = 20, SD = 3). Three were excluded from linear mixed-models analysis for not following instructions. In this within-subjects study, participants engaged in the Cyberball game, completed the DIAMONDS brief, and answered mood state questions twice, experiencing both inclusion and exclusion conditions in a randomized order. To mitigate order effects, conditions were counterbalanced across the final sample (N=256), with half (128) starting in the "included" condition and the other half in the "excluded" condition.

Ethics statement. The study, conducted at {masked for peer-review} and approved by the IRB (00003099), adhered to ethical standards. Participants were informed about the study's aim, data anonymity, and their right to withdraw without consequence. Participation required informed consent.

Measures.

In Study 2, we will employ the same measures for assessing mood states, personality traits, and situational perception as in Study 1.

Analytical plan.

We calculated Pearson's correlation coefficients between the Big Five traits, the DIAMONDS, and mood states, and assessed the manipulation effectiveness using a paired *t*-test. To test our hypotheses, we implemented linear mixed-effects models (LMM) with by-subject random intercepts for dependent variables using the lme4 package in R. The models incorporated OCEAN traits, situational perception, and experimental condition (exclusion vs. inclusion) as fixed effects, and participant ID as a random intercept, with Feelings of Exclusion or Feelings of Neglect (Equation 1) as dependent variables:

Feelings_of_Exclusion | Feelings_of_Neglect

~OCEAN_traits+situational_perception+experimental_condition+(1|participant_ID)

(1)

At Level 1 (within-person), momentary feelings of exclusion or neglect were predicted by the experimental condition and situational perception:

$$Feelings_{ij} = \beta_{0j} + \beta_{1(Condition_{ij})} + \beta_{2(SituationalPerception_{ij})} + r_{ij}$$

At Level 2 (between-person), the intercept was modeled as a function of individual differences in Big Five traits:

$$\beta_{0j} = \gamma_{00} + \gamma_{01(OCEAN_j)} + u_{0j}$$

Where i indexes measurement occasions, j indexes participants, r_{ij} is the Level 1 residual error term, and u_{0j} is the Level 2 random effect for participant j.

The model fit and variance explained were evaluated using the restricted maximum likelihood (REML) estimation. We calculated unique predictions for each predictor by the sum of square type II, aggregating unique effects from the DIAMONDS, Big Five, and experimental manipulation to determine their relative importance in explaining the observed phenomena.

Results

Manipulation Check. Manipulation check measured participants' perceived ball reception time, confirmed the experiment's success ((t(122) = -8.08, p < .001, d = -0.85)).

Descriptive statistics and correlational analysis. Table 5 presents descriptive statistics (means, standard deviations, mean differences, and effect sizes) for the DIAMONDS dimensions, Big Five traits, and mood states by experimental condition. Correlations among these variables are displayed separately in Figure 4 as a heatmap to improve clarity. Like Study 1, Study 2 found high ratings in Duty, Positivity, and Sociality for the Cyberball situation, with Mating and Intellect showing the lowest means. Negativity and Deception were rated higher in the exclusion condition. Pearson correlations, visualized in Figure 4, revealed significant associations between feelings of neglect and exclusion and the situational perceptions of Adversity, Negativity, Positivity, and Deception across conditions, except for Deception in the exclusion condition. Mating showed no significant correlations in either condition, and no significant associations were found between feelings of neglect or exclusion and the Big Five personality traits.

Table 5

Means, standard deviations, mean differences, and effect size.

Variable	Inclusion	Exclusion	*t*	p-value	*d*
C	42.43 (7.06)		-	-	-
E	47.08 (5.46)		-	-	-
O	42.04 (7.7)		-	-	-
N	38.25 (8.35)		-	-	-
A	46.91 (7.14)		-	-	-
Duty	10.43 (2.83)	9.88 (3.15)	-3.94	<0.001	-3.94
Intellect	6.46 (3.45)	6.46 (3.44)	0.05	0.96	0.05
Adversity	5.68 (2.8)	6.94 (3.25)	7.04	<0.001	7.04
Mating	5.72 (2.78)	5.74 (2.91)	0.14	0.89	0.14
Positivity	10.74 (2.86)	9.02 (3.22)	-8.28	<0.001	-8.28
Negativity	7.44 (3.06)	9.49 (3.05)	9.55	<0.001	9.55
Deception	7.6 (3.15)	8.11 (3.1)	3.21	<0.001	3.21
Sociality	9.77 (3.53)	9.62 (3.56)	-0.93	0.35	-0.93
Angry	1.88 (1.05)	2.61 (1.26)	8.75	<0.001	8.75
Good	3.63 (0.9)	2.9 (1.08)	-9.56	<0.001	-9.56
Bad	1.91 (0.98)	2.52 (1.15)	7.47	<0.001	7.47
Happy	3.42 (1.01)	2.66 (1.07)	-9.90	<0.001	-9.90
Sad	1.82 (0.97)	2.49 (1.21)	7.95	<0.001	7.95
Friendly	3.5 (1.06)	2.94 (1.16)	-7.37	<0.001	-7.37
Unfriendly	1.84 (0.99)	2.37 (1.16)	6.50	<0.001	6.50
Tense	2.23 (1.16)	2.92 (1.27)	7.71	<0.001	7.71
Relaxed	3.42 (1.1)	2.76 (1.14)	-8.33	<0.001	-8.33
Ignored	2.68 (1.25)	3.86 (1.29)	11.66	<0.001	11.66
Excluded	2.55 (1.24)	3.78 (1.35)	11.93	<0.001	11.93

Note. SD are within parentheses. Note: N=256; E=Extraversion; A=Agreeableness; N=Negative Emotionality; C=Conscientiousness; O=Open-mindedness.

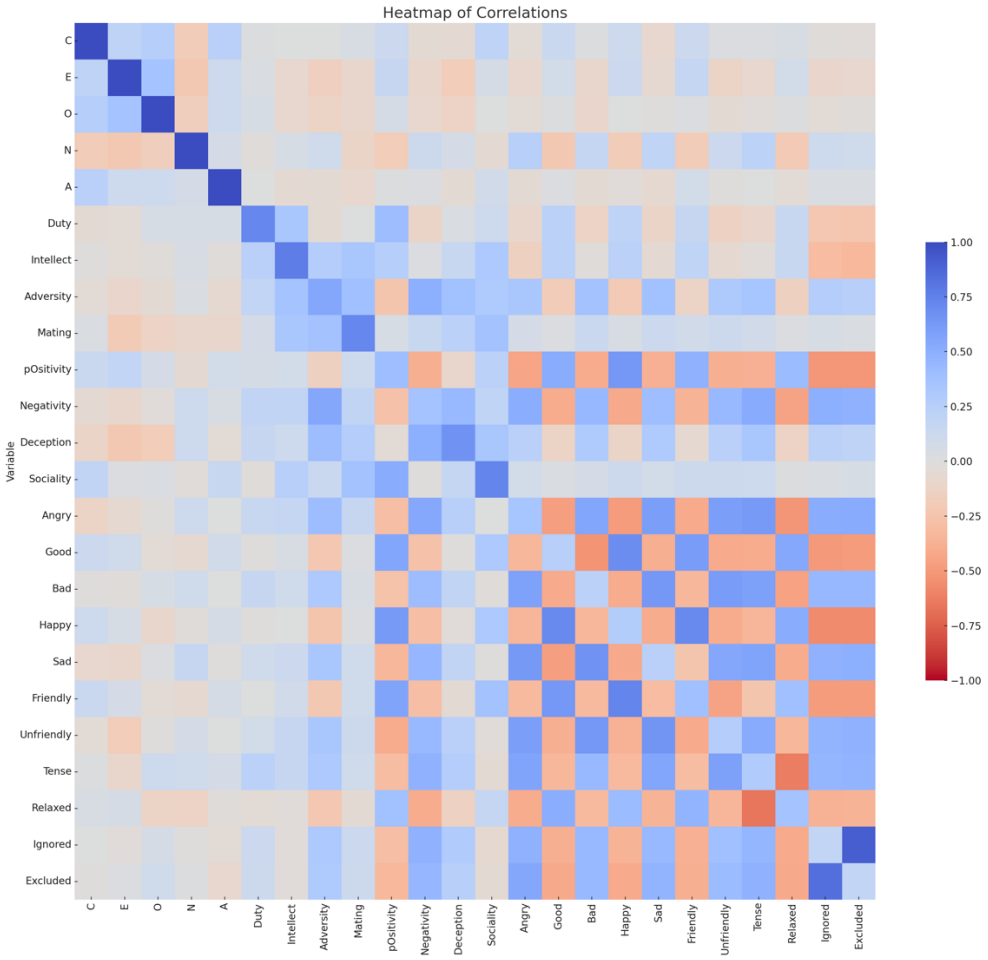


Figure 4.

Heatmap of Correlations Among DIAMONDS Dimensions, Big Five Traits, and Mood States. The color scale represents Pearson correlation coefficients ranging from -1 (red) to +1 (blue). N=256.

Differences in situational perception. Welch paired *t*-tests were used to assess how social exclusion influenced situational perception after the Cyberball game. The findings indicated that social exclusion led to a decrease in perceived Duty and Positivity, and an increase in perceived Adversity, Deception, and notably, Negativity, which had the highest effect size. Figure 5 show mean trends from inclusion to exclusion.

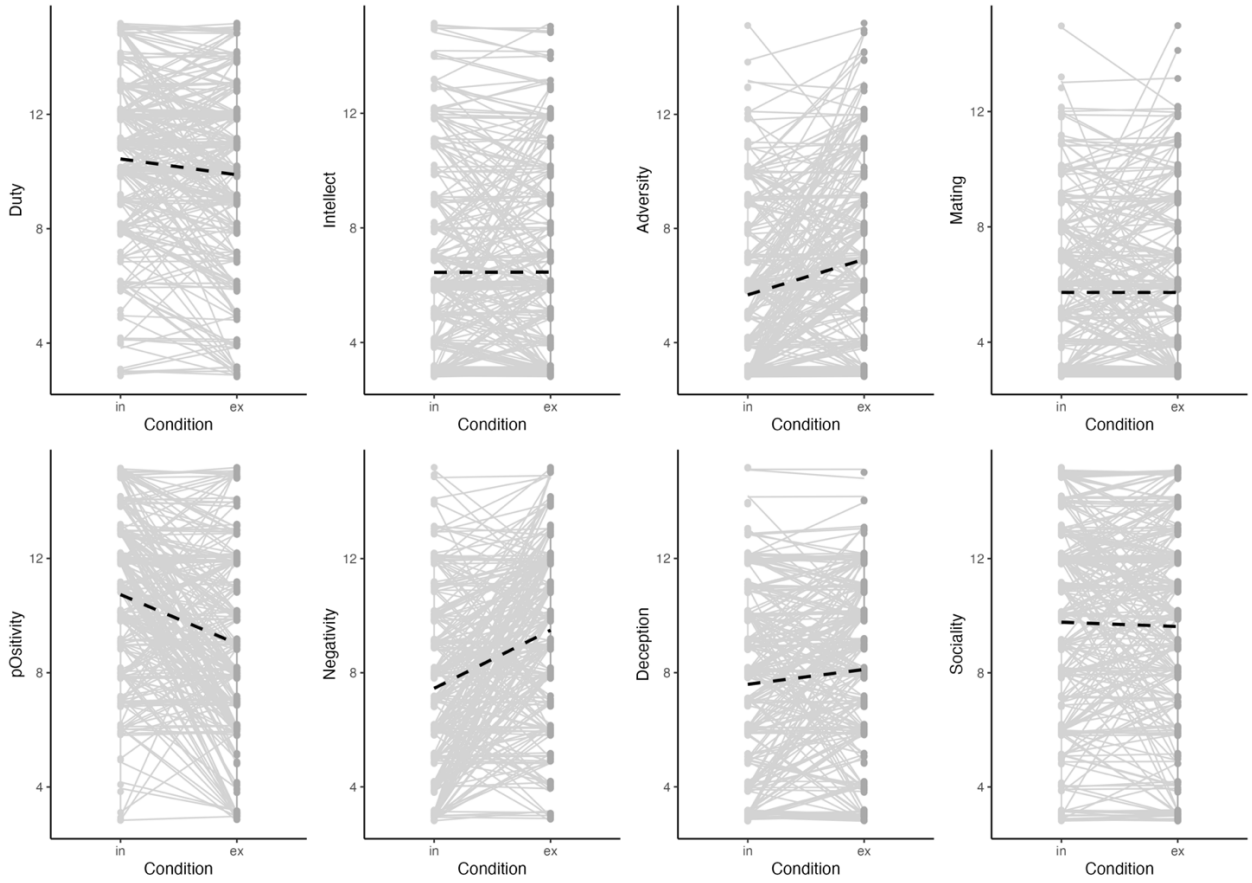


Figure 5

Intraindividual change in situational perception (DIAMONDS) between the inclusion and exclusion conditions. The dashed line displays mean change. in = Social Inclusion; ex = Social Exclusion. N=256.

Prediction of neglect and exclusion. For "I felt ignored," the model explained 56.8% of the variance, with 47.25% attributed to fixed effects. It revealed that being in the inclusion condition significantly reduced feelings of being ignored compared to exclusion. Significant predictors included higher Intellect and Negativity and lower Positivity, with no significant associations for other personality traits or predictors.

Regarding "I felt excluded," the model explained 54.49% of the variance (47.21% from fixed effects). Being in the inclusion condition led to lower "I felt excluded" scores.

Intellect and Positivity were negatively associated with feelings of exclusion, whereas Negativity and Sociality were positively correlated, with Open Mindedness showing a marginal relationship. The Big Five traits did not significantly predict "I felt excluded."

Table 7

Linear mixed-effects model results for "Feelings of ignoration"

Effect		Variance	SD	Estimate	SE	df	*t*	*p*
Random effects								
	Participants' intercept	0.1935	0.4398					
	Residual	0.8721	0.9338					
Fixed effects								
	(Intercept)			2.60	0.72	263.48	3.62	<0.001
	Social inclusion			-0.64	0.09	304.87	-7.09	<0.001
	Duty			0.02	0.02	363.66	1.12	0.26
	Intellect			-0.09	0.02	376.01	-5.59	<0.001
	Adversity			0.04	0.02	464.12	1.86	0.06
	Mating			0.03	0.02	419.31	1.37	0.17
	Positivity			-0.11	0.02	478.89	-5.74	<0.001
	Negativity			0.15	0.02	481.98	7.45	<0.001
	Deception			0.02	0.02	405.95	1.12	0.26
	Sociality			0.02	0.02	412.14	0.94	0.35
	C			0.01	0.01	249.31	0.70	0.49
	E			0.00	0.01	250.70	0.17	0.87
	O			0.01	0.01	246.16	1.17	0.24
	N			0.00	0.01	246.97	0.05	0.96
	A			0.00	0.01	244.67	-0.56	0.57

Notes: $N_{Observations}$=516 (2 observations per participant, social inclusion condition versus social exclusion), $N_{Participants}$=256. E=Extraversion; A=Agreeableness; N=Negative Emotionality; C=Conscientiousness; O=Open-mindedness. df=Degrees of Freedom.

Table 8

Linear mixed-effects model results for "Feelings of exclusion"

Effect		Variance	SD	Estimate	SE	df	T	*p*
Random effects								
	Participants' intercept	0.1525	0.3903					
	Residual	0.9514	0.9754					
Fixed effects								
	(Intercept)			2.64	0.72	259.67	3.67	<.001
	Social inclusion			-0.68	0.09	302.46	-7.3	<.001
	Duty			0.02	0.02	351.94	1.14	0.25
	Intellect			-0.09	0.02	364.73	-5.8	<.001
	Adversity			0.04	0.02	452.25	1.73	0.08
	Mating			0.02	0.02	406.9	1.15	0.25
	Positivity			-0.13	0.02	469.45	-6.9	<.001
	Negativity			0.14	0.02	472.46	6.64	<.001
	Deception			0.01	0.02	392.14	0.51	0.61
	Sociality			0.04	0.02	398.96	2.17	0.03
	C			0	0.01	246.42	0.05	0.96
	E			0.01	0.01	247.71	0.92	0.36
	O			0.01	0.01	243.56	1.74	0.08
	N			0	0.01	243.69	0.37	0.71
	A			-0.01	0.01	241.05	-1.19	0.23

Notes: $N_{Observations}$=516 (2 observations per participant, social inclusion condition versus social exclusion), $N_{Participants}$=256. E=Extraversion; A=Agreeableness; N=Negative Emotionality; C=Conscientiousness; O=Open-mindedness.

Unique prediction and variance partitioning of neglect and exclusion. Figure 6 displays the combined impact of experimental manipulation, the DIAMONDS dimensions, and the Big Five traits on the explained variance of feelings of neglect and exclusion, highlighting situational perceptions as the predominant source of unique effects. Specifically, situational perceptions explain about 70%-71% of the variance, whereas the Big Five traits account for only 1%-3%. This reaffirms Study 1's findings that the DIAMONDS dimensions play a more significant role than the Big Five in explaining these feelings. Additionally, experimental manipulation itself contributes to 27%-28% of the variance.

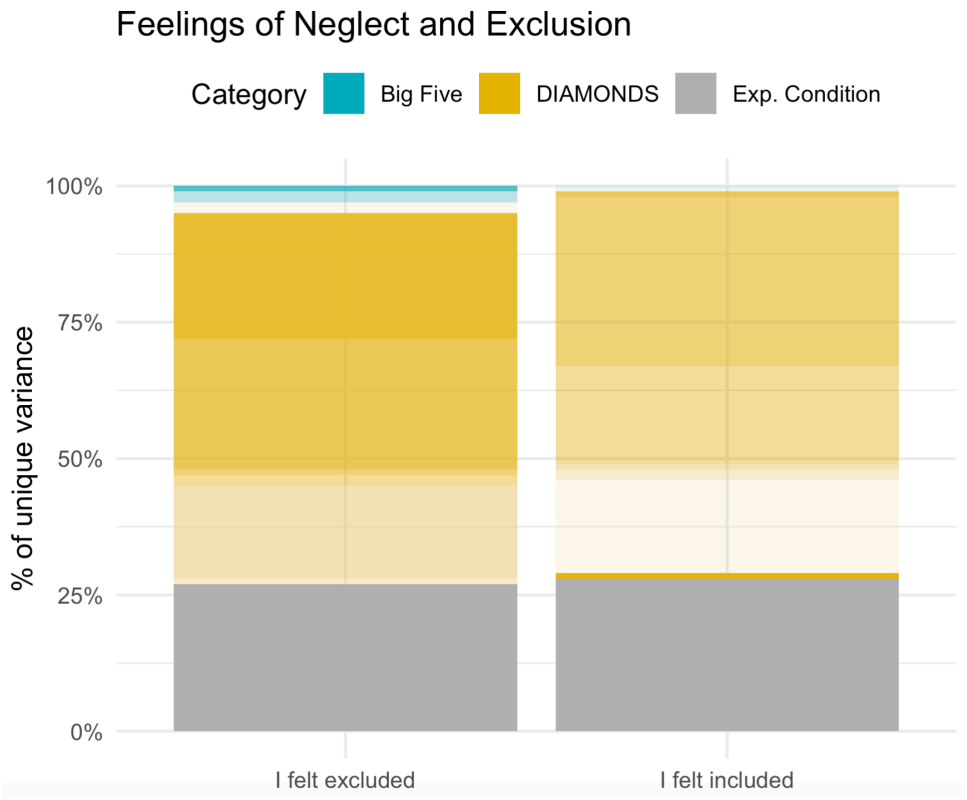


Figure 6

Unique effects of experimental manipulation (Exp. Condition), situational perception (DIAMONDS) and personality (Big Five) on the variance of feelings of ignoration and

exclusion. Slight color variations within each bar correspond to different predictors within the same category. N=256.

Discussion

This study sought to examine the impact of experimental manipulation (social inclusion vs. exclusion) on situational perception and its predictive power, alongside personality traits, on feelings of social exclusion and neglect using a within-subjects design. Consistent with our hypotheses, significant effects were found of the experimental conditions on situational perception, as well as on feelings of being ignored and excluded, supporting Rauthmann & Sherman's (2016) emphasis on the critical role of situational factors in influencing individuals' emotional experiences.

Our results suggest that social exclusion significantly alters situational perceptions, supporting Hypothesis H2.1, with excluded participants perceiving their environment as more adverse, negative, and deceitful compared to included participants. Consistent with prior research suggesting that early emotional responses to ostracism are relatively automatic and minimally moderated by personality traits (e.g., McDonald & Donnellan, 2012; Hales et al., 2016), Study 2 also found that personality traits did not significantly predict feelings of neglect or exclusion, in line with Hypothesis H2.2. This highlights situational perception's role over personality traits in influencing emotions, echoing findings by Wilms, Lanwehr, and Kastenmüller (2020) on the context-dependent nature of situational factors. Additionally, the DIAMONDS dimensions were key in explaining the variance in feelings of neglect and exclusion, underscoring situational perception's critical influence on emotional experiences, over the Big Five personality traits.

General Discussion

In two separate experiments, we explored the effect of situational cue manipulation on situational perception, disregarding the influence of personality traits. Findings from both studies indicated that situational manipulation, alongside personality traits and situational perceptions, significantly predicted affect. Despite a correlation between personality and situational perception, each contributed uniquely to affect variance, validated through both between-subjects and within-subjects experimental designs. This suggested a causal connection between situational cue alterations and changes in situational perception, highlighting situational perception's critical role in affecting cognitive and emotional responses, which can ultimately impact behavior. However, we acknowledge that the current studies did not directly measure behavior, and interpretations regarding behavioral consequences should remain cautious. While our within-subjects design strengthens the causal interpretation of the effects of social exclusion on situational perception and affect, future research employing time-lagged designs would be necessary to fully clarify the directionality between changes in situational perception and subsequent affective states. These results offer significant insights into the dynamics of situation perception and its behavioral consequences.

Changes in situation cues cause changes in situational perception. This study aligns with and extends the theories posited by Rauthmann et al. (2014; 2015) and Horstmann & Ziegler (2019), investigating the plausible causal links between situational cues and characteristics, a concept previously untested despite its inclusion in the research agenda by Rauthmann & Sherman (2019). It suggests the first causal evidence that situational cues directly influence affect and situation characteristics, independently of personality traits, challenging earlier indirect evidence by Rauthmann & Sherman (2016) and Horstmann et al. (2021). This evidence supports the model where situational perception arises from both

personal aspects (like personality traits) and situational cues, suggesting that situational perception, rather than being influenced by affect states, may influence them, a notion requiring further exploration as indicated by Colom et al. (2019) and contrasting with Rauthmann et al. (2015). Across two studies, similar patterns were observed in how social exclusion affects situational perception dimensions like Negativity, Adversity, Positivity, and Deception, with Duty uniquely reflecting differences between inclusion and exclusion scenarios. These findings underscore the complex relationship between situational cues and individual perceptions, advocating for more research to understand these dynamics better.

Situation perception predicts feelings of neglect and exclusion independently of personality traits. In our exploration of the effects of situation cues on situational perception and its interplay with personality traits in affecting feelings of neglect and exclusion, we found that situational manipulation significantly impacts perceptions of positivity and negativity. These perceptions consistently predicted feelings of neglect and exclusion, indicating situational factors' critical role in shaping emotional experiences, as supported by external cues' influence on behavior in literature (Hess et al., 2009; Gollwitzer, 1999; Buades-Rotger et al., 2023). Discrepancies between Adversity in a between-persons design and Intellect and Sociality in a within-persons design suggest different underlying processes at the intraindividual level. Our findings align with the notion that situation characteristics and personality traits independently predict state behaviors (Sherman et al., 2015), with situational perception explaining a significantly larger variance in affect and behavior than personality traits, especially noted in Study 2's focus on intraindividual differences. This reinforces the argument for situational perception's critical role in behavior prediction (Fleeson, 2001; Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015; Rauthmann et al., 2019). Future research directions include investigating personality disorders, employing actual behavior assessments, and utilizing virtual reality to assess trait-like situation perception tendencies

(Hartgerink et al., 2015; Gallardo-Pujol & Buades-Rotger, 2019). For now, we conclude that situation perception is the most potent predictor of *in situ* behavior. Finally, the utility of within-person differences in situation perception for predicting within-person differences in behavior still requires further examination.

Implications for personality theories. This research adds evidence of plausible causality and integrating the role of situational perceptions in previous trait theories of personality (Horstman et al., 2021; Sherman et al., 2015). While most personality theories (e.g., Fleeson & Jayawickreme, 2015; McCrae & Costa, 2008; Mischel & Shoda, 1995) don't primarily focus on situations, trait activation theory (Tett & Guterman, 2000) emphasizes person-situation interactions, a stance supported by Sherman et al. (2015). This study supports the idea that situational cues and perceptions, beyond personality traits, can influence behavioral changes, engaging with the person-situation debate as discussed by Donnellan, Lucas, & Fleeson (2009); Funder (2006). Contrary to Mischel's (1968) early observations on the marginal impact of personality traits on behavior, a modern consensus acknowledges both stable traits and situational factors in behavior formation (Funder, 2001; Mischel, Shoda, & Mendoza-Denton, 2002; Sherman et al., 2010). However, there's been a lack of experimental data to support this. This research indicates that situational perceptions independently predict behaviors, urging personality theories to integrate the effects of situational factors (Horstmann et al., 2019; Lewin, 1935; Rauthmann et al., 2014), and to consider the role of situational perception in predicting behaviors and informing personality assessments.

Limitations. This study enhances understanding of situation perception's role in social exclusion but acknowledges limitations. The sample's predominance of female undergraduate students may restrict generalizability, given that sample composition is known to influence

situation perception (Horstmann & Ziegler, 2020). Although aimed for a power of 90%, the actual sample sizes of n=349 in Study 1 and n=259 in Study 2 resulted in an achieved power of approximately 80%. The within-subjects design of Study 2 raises the possibility of carryover effects, which were only partially addressed through counterbalancing. The analysis was confined to linear relationships, overlooking potential nonlinear interactions and trait-situation perception interactions that could predict behavior variance (Blum, Rauthmann, Göllner, Lischetzke, & Schmitt, 2018; Schmitt et al., 2013). Cultural and technological influences on situational perception and social exclusion, such as the impact of augmented or virtual realities (Gallardo-Pujol & Buades-Rotger, 2019), remain unexplored. Reliance on self-reports without external validation poses a further limitation, suggesting future research could benefit from incorporating diverse assessment methods to provide a more comprehensive analysis. Additionally, the data for Study 2 were collected shortly after the COVID-19 lockdowns in Spain (May–June 2020), which may have influenced participants' sensitivity to social exclusion and situational cues, limiting the generalizability of the findings to other contexts.

Summary and Conclusion

What transpires when a situation alters the cues it presents? Does this instigate changes in how individuals perceive the situation? Does it prompt modifications in their behaviors? This study investigates the effects of changing situational cues on individual perceptions and behaviors, particularly in the context of social exclusion. Findings reveal that individuals' behaviors align with their perceptions of situations, with social exclusion leading to perceptions of negativity and adversity, contrasting with those included. Contrary to expectations, personality traits do not significantly predict variance in self-reported affect or behavior. Instead, dimensions of Positivity and Negativity emerge as predictors of affect and

markers of exclusion across both between- and within-participant studies, as highlighted by Horstmann et al. (2021) and Rauthmann et al. (2014). These results suggest that situational perception may contribute to understanding momentary psychological experiences beyond what is captured by traditional personality traits. However, we recognize that traits and situational perceptions operate at different levels of analysis, and that the predictive value of situation perception for broader life outcomes remains an open question.

Additionally, the study underscores situational factors' dominant role over personality traits in predicting social exclusion and neglect feelings. This indicates that interventions targeting social exclusion might benefit from focusing on modifying situational perceptions rather than solely on personality traits. Future research is encouraged to further explore the complex relationship between situational perception, personality traits, and social exclusion.

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